

Detention of Palestinian student in Vt. shocks friends

‘Advocate for peace’ feared appointment for civics test was a ruse

By Paul Heintz
GLOBE CORRESPONDENT

When federal officials led a handcuffed Mohsen Mahdawi out of an office building in northern Vermont on Monday, he became the latest international student whom the Trump administration had apparently targeted for speaking out against Israel’s war in Gaza.

But those who know Mahdawi say it’s absurd to suggest he “engaged in pro-terrorist, anti-Semitic, anti-American activity,” as the president has said of protesters at Columbia University where he was a student. Rather, they describe him as a peaceful 34-year-old

Palestinian who had a remarkable journey from a refugee camp in the West Bank to a cabin in rural Vermont to an Ivy League institution in New York City.

He is widely known in the upper Connecticut River Valley of Vermont and New Hampshire, where he has been based since moving to the United States more than a decade ago, as a spiritual man who grew up Muslim, is a practicing Buddhist, and whose closest friends are Jewish.

“He is such an advocate for peace. He is such an opponent of any kind of violence,” said Rabbi Dov Taylor, who leads Chavurat Ki-tov, a

Scientists raise flags on RFK autism pledge

Fear decades of research into complex condition will be undermined

By Kay Lazar
GLOBE STAFF

One Boston lab is scrutinizing brain waves of infants to detect very early signs of autism. Another is studying how fevers in children with autism may be linked to a dramatic but temporary reduction in symptoms. Others are measuring how the brains of people with the developmental disorder process information differently than those without the condition.

Researchers across the region, who’ve spent years deciphering autism, say Health and Human Services Secretary Robert F. Kennedy Jr.’s pledge to determine what causes autism by September is not only wildly unrealistic, it may undermine decades of science by promoting discredited theories about a complex condition that affects millions of children in the United States.

The mounting uneasiness comes as the number of children diagnosed with autism, which affects how people communicate and interact with the world, continues to rise. The latest numbers, released Tuesday by the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention, show

AUTISM, Page A5

Harvard tax status under attack

Trump administration presses IRS to revoke school’s exempt standing, reports say

By Jim Puzzanghera, Nick Stoico, and Tonya Alanez
GLOBE STAFF

WASHINGTON — President Trump is escalating his battle against Harvard University as news reports Wednesday said the administration is pushing the Internal Revenue Service to revoke the school’s tax-exempt status.

President Trump had threatened the move on social media on Tuesday

after Harvard refused to comply with administration demands to make policy changes and agree to federal oversight amid tensions over the school’s diversity, equity, and inclusion policies and the handling of Gaza war protests.

“Perhaps Harvard should lose its Tax Exempt Status and be Taxed as a Political Entity if it keeps pushing political, ideological, and terrorist inspired/supporting “Sickness?””

Fed weighs in

Jerome Powell warned that Trump’s tariff plan would most likely lead to even higher inflation and slower growth than initially expected **D1**.

Deportation case

A federal judge threatened to open a contempt investigation into whether the Trump administration violated his order. **A2**.

Trump wrote on his social media site. “Remember, Tax Exempt Status is totally contingent on acting in the PUBLIC INTEREST!”

The Washington Post and CNN reported that Trump was moving ahead with the threat.

Citing three unnamed people familiar with the situation, the Post said the Treasury Department has asked the IRS’s top attorney to take

HARVARD, Page A6

‘The uncertainty is almost as bad as the problem itself.’

TODD BLOUNT, *chief executive, Blount Fine Foods*



PHOTOS BY DAVID L. RYAN/GLOBE STAFF

Maritza Loza worked at Blount Fine Foods in Fall River. The company imports broccoli from Mexico and Guatemala.

Triggered by tariffs

Massachusetts manufacturers struggle to make plans amid chaos

By Omar Mohammed
GLOBE STAFF

FALL RIVER — They make their products in America, the kind of domestic manufacturing President Trump says he wants to encourage with his punishing tariffs on the country’s global trading partners.

But the plush cotton in the luxurious towels the linen company Matouk makes here comes from Egypt; the broccoli in the prepared dishes Blount Fine Foods sells to restaurants comes from Guatemala and Mexico; and while a lot of the raw materials Davico uses to manufacture automotive parts in nearby New Bedford come from the United States, some are imported from



Marilemny Travez Gonzales sewed goods at Matouk, a nearly century-old luxury linen manufacturer based in Fall River.

as far away as India.

Here, on the South Coast of Massachusetts, where manufacturers already employ thousands, where production lines already churn out American-made goods for sale to American consumers, the whipsaw of tariff directives from Trump has filled factory bosses with annoyance, dread, and feelings of paralysis.

“This is a very frustrating thing as a manufacturer,” said George Matouk Jr., who runs a nearly century-old maker of fine linens. “These universal and reciprocal tariffs, which are supposed to provide [an] incentive for manufacturing investment in the United States, are actually

TARIFFS, Page A7

Mother and son run for remembrance



JESSICA RINALDI/GLOBE STAFF

Ben Burgess is running his first Boston Marathon this year and will be joined by his mother, Lisa Burgess, a veteran marathoner.

After a father’s death by suicide, they find healing and purpose in Marathon

By Claire Thornton
GLOBE STAFF

When Ben Burgess was 8 years old, his dad placed both hands on his shoulders and told him “You’re the man of the house now.” Then he walked out the front door of the family’s Framingham home, leaving his wife and four young children behind.

In the years that followed, Eric Burgess battled alcoholism and struggled with his mental health. In 2016, he took his own life.

On Monday, Ben, now 24, will run his first Boston Marathon, carrying with him the memories of his father — and the man’s struggles.

Each stride helps him find a balance between grief and solace, between the trauma he’s endured and the freedom that running offers. His mother, Lisa Burgess, a veteran marathoner, will also run Boston.

MARATHON, Page A4

The Justice Department sued Maine’s Department of Education over its refusal to comply with demands to ban transgender athletes from participating in women’s sports. **A2**.

Britain’s highest civil court issued a ruling that the definition of “woman” under the country’s gender equality law is based on a person’s sex at birth. **A3**.

Massachusetts House leaders released a \$61.4 billion state budget plan that would hike spending by more than 6 percent. **B1**.

Boston Public Schools beginning in May will automatically pause transportation services for students who do not consistently ride the bus, district and city leaders said. **B1**.



Sol provider

Thursday: Sunny, breezy. High: 57-62. Low: 38-43.

Friday: Sun then clouds. High: 58-63. Low: 49-54.

Sunrise: 6:00 Sunset: 7:28

Comics and Weather, **D5-6**.

Obituaries, **C9**.

VOL. 307, NO. 107

Suggested retail price
\$4.00

